You Know I'm a Hugger

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30063252.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra)

Characters:
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Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, Post-War, Scorpia (She-Ra) is a Good Friend, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, POV Scorpia (She-Ra), Therapy Cat Melog (She-Ra), Bright Moon (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) is a Dork, Feel-good, Everyone Gets A Hug, Leather Jackets, Fluff, Entrapta Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Queen Glimmer (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra) Is an Idiot

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Our Fires Within

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by 4theHonourofGräysküll (AVAwolfpack), But_Its_For_Science (DakianDelomast), DakianDelomast

Summary

After the war against Horde Prime for the fate of Etheria, there is a lot of cleaning up to do after She-Ra released the magic. The Best Friends Squad is assembling for their next adventure. Despite the war being over some wounds still need to heal. They need some help from someone who is brave, strong, loyal, and gives great hugs.

Good thing Scorpia is here to breathe in a new day to the world that they live in, and help her friends through their trying times together. That first task is taking Catra on her first tour of Bright Moon.

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Welcome to the Prologue to our series! We've tasked Scorpia with assembling and supporting the team to prepare them for the BFS adventures in *~SPACE~* following the defeat of Horde Prime. Each chapter update introduces the newest novella in the series so stay tuned here for updates!

Notes

Hello everyone! The adventures of Scorpia on Etheria post-Prime will be introducing each new novella in our series. So every time a Scorpia chapter drops, look forward to the novella coming the same week. We've certainly given her a big task, but if anyone can handle it, it's her. This is a prelude to our first novella A Light in the Dark. A story about Catra and how she is dealing with her past and trying her hardest to make up for the awful things she did.

A Tour of Bright Moon

I snip through the thick vine with my pincers and watch the disconnected foliage slip away from the door. Another choice cut here and there and the doorway is finally opened again. I step back and survey my work, wiping the sweat from my brow with a forearm.

"One door down!"

"And like a billion more to go," Mermista groans, gesturing at the series of archways covered by intrusive foliage. She follows me a pace behind to the next.

My pincers cut through the first section of vines indiscriminately, taking out a huge chunk. It's nice to be able to cut something without worrying. When I help Perfuma in her gardens in Plumeria, I'm also so nervous of messing it up. Even though she assures me she can just regrow it, she never does. I'm always so clumsy, but she never seems to notice or mind.

"Oh, isn't today great? The fresh air! All those new birds that have shown up again now that the magic is free! I couldn't ask for better." The vines fall away and I see the first hints of the halls of Bright Moon hidden behind.

"Sure," Mermista says. "And we're stuck cutting weeds."

"You know, it's funny, but Perfuma says there's no such thing as weeds." My pincers slice through the verdant green foliage with ease. The contact sends a pleasant tingle up my arm—the vigor and life released from the Heart within the vines. "It's a term people made up to describe an unwanted plant. But all plants should be wanted. I gotta say, I agree with her. Growing up in the Fright Zone, we didn't have weeds *or* plants. These things are great! I'm still on the fence about the eating them part but I'm getting there."

Mermista leans against the nearby wall, her arms crossed. "Right. Well, can't say I want a bunch of plants blocking everything. I don't see why She-Ra had to zap *all* of Etheria with plants."

"That was pretty cool wasn't it?" More vines fall to the ground. I think of the burst of diaphanous light shooting from She-Ra's sword. The overwhelming glow and warmth of the warrior. "She made a tree *in space!* " I laugh as I cut another vine. "Who does that?"

"I'm just saying she could have stopped there." She flicked a leaf off her shoulder. "Salineas is still covered in seaweed and I'm *soooooo* not looking forward to clearing that out."

"Say, why aren't you in Salineas right now?"

"I'm waiting for Perfuma to be done with whatever she's doing so she can just take care of it for me." She waves a hand dismissively. "Why waste my time when she can just control all the plants out of the way or whatever."

Another two cuts of my pincers and this archway is clear. "Well, shoot! I'll come by any time." I click my pincers together pointedly. "I'm really good at cutting stuff."

Mermista smirks at me. "Sure. Why not, Scorps?"

"I always liked the sea."

We make our way to the next archway but stop short when a familiar neigh catches my attention. I shield my eyes against the brightness of the afternoon sun and look up. The winged unicorn blended in surprisingly well with the polychromatic sky, but I spot Swift Wind swooping down toward us.

"Hey, Swift Wind!" I wave at him excitedly, Mermista ducking away from my exuberance. "Good to see you buddy!"

He lands elegantly on the stones of the pavilion and tosses his head back, his magnificent mane flowing in the wind. "Greetings friends!" he says. "I bear good news! The apples in the orchards of Thaymor have been freed of their confinement from the excess foliage." He tosses his head back in triumph. "Apples for all of Etheria!"

"Ooh, that *is* great news!" I say.

"Sure." Mermista crosses her arms, her expression flat and unimpressed by Swift Wind's opulence. "Thaymor's where Glimmer, Bow and Adora were right? Does that mean they're coming back?"

"And Catra!" Swift Wind says.

I should have expected it. I knew Catra was travelling with everyone now. After the Battle at the Heart, when she had apologized and I hugged her, it had seemed like everything would be okay. I wanted it to be okay. But hearing her name still catches me off guard. A knot forms in my chest and I have to breathe in deep and let it out slowly, like Perfuma taught me, for it to go away. The smile on my face barely slipped for that half second before it's back.

"The Queen's excursion to Thaymor was an astounding success," Swift Wind continues, unaware of the brief intrusion. "They're on their way back right now!" He pauses and looks around, noticing the vines covering all the doorways and he frowns. "A horse can't fit through there."

"Oh, jeez. You're right!" I go to the nearest archway and cut a larger opening through the plants. "Does that work better for you buddy?"

"It does!" Swift Wind canters up to it happily. "You know, now that the magic has been released back into Etheria, I plan on establishing my own council of horsekind. It's about time we made all doorways horse friendly and—"

However, Swift Wind's plans for his council are cut short by a burst of light in the air as Glimmer materializes with Bow, Adora, and Catra in tow.

"Nope," Catra groans and doubles over, holding her hands on her knees. "I'm not doing that again, Sparkles."

Glimmer puts her hands on her hips. "Well, *I'm* not walking everywhere."

"Great. I'll see you around then."

Adora crouches next to Catra, patting her gently on the back. "You also said no to riding Swift Wind."

Catra lifts her head just enough to give her a glare. "If you think I'd rather be flying on a horse you accidentally *zapped with magic* —"

"C'mon, guys," Bow says, slinging an arm over Glimmer's shoulders. "It's only been a few days, Catra. Maybe just give it some time and you'll get used to it."

Catra shakes her head and drops it in resignation. She lets out the irritated groan I know so well. There's still a delicate flutter in my chest, looking at her like this. That strange sense of comfort, wanting to swaddle her up and let her know it's okay, even if it's just a tummy ache. I raise my pincer to speak up. Maybe I can—

Mermista steps in front of me before I can say anything. "Glimmer, I *have* to get out of here. Can we just, like, go get Perfuma and maybe take her Salineas?"

Glimmer's eyes narrow at Mermista before she rolls them. "Oh, *suuure* ! Anywhere *else* you want to go?"

"Wow, who brought the sassy queen back?" Mermista holds up a hand in a fake placating gesture before planting it on her hip. "At least I don't complain about your teleports."

"Ugh. Fine." Glimmer throws out an offering hand. "But you only get one a day. I have *a kingdom to run* , you know!"

"Um… We *all* have kingdoms to run, but fine. I won't keep you long." Mermista turns to salute me sarcastically. "See ya, Scorps! Good seeing you guys again. Now that we're not all trying to kill each other or trying not to get killed that is."

I gingerly wave back. "Agreed, on both parts!"

"You ready?" Glimmer says impatiently before grabbing onto Mermista's hand and they poof away in a cloud of sparkles. My pincer is still raised in my brief goodbye wave.

"Okay!" Adora claps her hands together and turns to Catra, who has just barely gotten to her feet in the meantime. There's a tightness to her eyes lingering from the discomfort. "What do you wanna see first?"

Catra startles and her tail stiffens.

Adora starts counting the stops on her fingers, raising them as she tacks on another checkpoint on their tour. "There's the waterfalls—that *aren't* showers apparently—the dining room, the throne room, the portrait hall, the gardens. I guess we're kinda already in the gardens." She chuckles awkwardly and looks around at the overgrown foliage. She turns back to Catra, smiling broadly. "So? Where do you wanna start?"

"Oh… I…" Catra hesitates, her ears flattening. Her arm creeps across her body to grab the other by the elbow.

Adora really should be more sensitive when Catra is on edge like this. I step forward to intervene—

"Wow." Bow takes his goggles from his belt and dons them with an electronic whirr taking over the quiet silence between the birds chirping. "We've got a lot left to go."

"Yeah, sorry. That's my bad," I say, rubbing a pincer at the back of my neck. "I've been working on clearing the hallways, but you know—" I click my pincers together "—only so much two pincers can cut at a time."

"I mean, if it's anyone's fault, it's mine. Who knew all the power stored in the heart of the planet would make everything explode with plants, right?"Adora holds up her hands and shrugs, chuckling awkwardly again. When no one joins her, she deflates and grips her forearm subconsciously.

"If it was going to explode with anything, I—for one—am *glad* that it's plants and not something else." I gesture around to the surrounding flowers soaking up the sunlight. A trill of birdsong accompanies my observations. "Look at all those colors! And those weird bird things flying around. Man—so many gosh darn new delights have popped up since you did that."

Adora smiles appreciatively at me and drops her hand from her forearm. "It would've been easier for everyone if all the buildings weren't covered. But… it's fine. They're just plants. We can walk around it. Catra's got her claws and I have my sword and—"

Swift Wind butts in with his head over Adora's shoulder. "And my horn!"

"Yes, Swiftie, and your horn." She pats him affectionately on the cheek, if not a little like a put-upon mother.

"Because kicking them was ineffective!"

She nods and pats him again. "Yes, it was."

"Uhhh." Bow adjusts a dial on the side of his goggles. Who knows what he's scanning for. I never understood all that tech stuff like he and Entrapta did. "I think we're going to need a *bit* more than that."

"Because they're magic plants?"

"Because they're magic plants."

Adora's shoulders slump and she sighs.

Bow gives her a knowing smile and bumps her lightly on the arm. "You know, I bet I have some herbicide arrows in my—Glimmer's room. But I might need a hand getting them."

"Great!" She perks up immediately and clenches a hand into a fist in excitement. "Let's take Swift Wind around the palace and grab them." She pinches her chin between her thumb and forefinger as a thought occurs to her. "Actually, taking Swiftie would be the fastest way to see Bright Moon."

"Loop-de-loops?" Swift Wind skips in delight. "Loop-de-loops!"

"C'mon, Catra. Let's go!" She grabs Catra by the hand and starts to drag her toward Swift Wind.

"No! Absolutely not!" Catra yanks her hand away and pounces a few feet back. Adora turns to her, brow furrowed in confusion as Catra hesitates and glances to the side. The tightness to her eyes from Glimmer's teleport returns. "No… loop-de-loops."

"Oh, okay." Adora looks at Swift Wind. "We don't have to do loop-de-loops. Right, Swiftie?"

Swift Wind frowns skeptically, a wing reaching around for a feather to stroke his chin. "Can you fly without doing at least one loop-de-loop? I thought it was natural law."

My pincer snaps into the air. "I'll take care of her!"

Bow, Adora, Swift Wind and Catra all turn to look at me at once, as though just remembering I was there. I tended to have that effect on people. I might be a big gal, but I could slip in and out of rooms unnoticed rather easily.

Adora frowns as she considers, an uncomfortable disappointment written in her eyes. I almost want to plead with

her to let me do this.

"I can give her a tour and maybe show her around while we cut through some of this! She's gotta know the grounds before she goes *flying around* them, right? I mean, not to brag—" I insert myself between Adora and Catra and put one of my arms over Catra's shoulders, while I touch the other pincer to my chest. "—but I happen to know these halls like the back of my claw right now. It'd be a breeze for me."

"Oh… Okay, I guess that works." Adora squeezes Catra's shoulder. "We'll be back soon enough. Take it easy."

"Oh, yeah, she's in good hands. Well *pincers.*" I chuckle. "Everything's fine! I have a lot of experience with a sick Catra."

Catra gives a resigned thumbs up. "Great. Sounds good."

"There was that one time we were on a boat—do you remember that?" I steer her away from Bow and Adora toward the most recently opened archway into the halls of Bright Moon. "Man, that seasickness really got to you then, huh? You had Kyle follow you around with a bucket."

We pass through the vines into the hall. The normally polished and shining floors are littered with detritus and dirt. Various vines creep up the walls to the high, vaulted ceilings. Several shrubs are rooted within cracks in the doorways and floor, barring entry into those rooms, at least at the moment. Even with all the clutter of the extra foliage surrounding us, the halls of Bright Moon still felt open and airy. Free and welcoming.

Catra walks next to me a little slumped, ears flat, arm crossed protectively over her. It's been a long time since I've seen her look so timid. Her eyes are trained on where the floor meets the wall.

"So… Space?" I venture. "Pretty big, huh?"

The hand hanging at her side wanders out into the open air between her and the wall. "Yup."

"Man, I can't imagine." I put my pincers on my hips and look up at the ceiling. "I mean, Swift Wind and I spent so many nights picking stars to look at thinking it'd be you guys up there. There were so many to pick from! Who would have thought there were that many stars? That's the portrait hall, by the way. We can't really go in there because of the vines but that's where it is."

Catra says nothing. Her hand slips to the back of her neck and I can't help but mimic the gesture, remembering all too well the pinching pain of the chip there. The feeling of my own will leeching from my body. Trapped at the back of my head, stuck watching while everything happened around me. Listening to my loved ones plead with me…

I drop my pincer and sigh. "That whole Prime chip stuff. Pretty scary. I thought for sure he was going to get the best of us."

"Y—Yeah. He nearly did." Catra realizes she's touching her neck and forces herself to drop her hand. She looks away.

We walk in silence. I study her, trying to pin down the unease within me. When I'd volunteered to take Catra on this tour, I'd been prepared to weather her biting comments and sarcasm. But this was almost worse. The hesitancy. The withdrawn look in her eyes. Her recovery was usually immaculate. She always managed to bounce back so fast. Even away from Adora's anticipation and excitement, she still wasn't quite… Quite the Catra I had expected.

"What's wrong?" I ask.

Catra snarls and glares sideyed at me. "Don't you start, too."

"Start what?"

"Just…" She turns away. "Nevermind."

"Ah, well Bright Moon is pretty overwhelming at first, you know?" I gesture around the wide open halls. Everything is admittedly more muted than usual with the overgrowth, but it's

still much more vibrant than the Fright Zone. "It's so noisy and everything smells so weird. At first, I was technically a prisoner, but the cell had all these pillows in it that were so soft and fluffy. I'm not sure they actually know what a cell is supposed to be like. They even gave me green stuff to eat. Remember? We always knew it was a bad time when the rations were green."

"Yeah, I remember." Catra takes a deep sniff and wrinkles her nose. Not quite in displeasure but discomfort. "It does smell weird. Is that… What is that?"

"Beats me! Looks like the throne room is still covered, too. Can't go in there either." I laugh and keep moving forward. "Oh! Guess what! The other day in the forest, I saw a mouse! A real mouse." I nudge her in the shoulder with my elbow. "Betcha can get one of those for Adora, huh?"

"That was *one* time." Catra huffs and dodges my next attempt to nudge her. The old, growling frustration was back in her voice. "Why does *everyone* keep bringing that up?"

"Sorry, sorry." I hold up my claws placatingly. "I was just thinking of nice stuff you could get her."

Catra collects herself, pausing to take a breath and let it out. I recognize it from Perfuma's guidance. She and Catra must have spent some time together. Not surprising she'd choose to help Catra—she was good at stuff like that.

"No, it's fine." Catra glances sideways at me. "I'm sorry. I've been working on that."

A glowing flash appears under her outstretched hand. A blue and purple translucent creature with glowing eyes. It lets out an echoing noise and presses its face into the palm of her hand.

I startle back and knock into a wall. "What the heck is that?"

Catra looks at me with wide-eyed surprise. "Sorry. I thought everyone…" She glances down at the creature who lets out

another noise. “You don’t remember Melog from the Heart?”

“Oh, not really.” I peel myself away from the wall. “Just, everything happened so fast and I think I was chipped then? I don’t really remember… I didn’t know they could do *that.* ”

Melog gives an echoing mew that causes Catra to look at them in surprise.

“What’re they saying?”

“Melog was with Bow in the terminal.” Her hand passes over the top of Melog’s head back into their mane. “They say you zapped them.”

The guilt surges through me. Perfuma told me all about what happened when I was chipped, all the things I don’t quite remember. She always assured me that people didn’t blame me—that I still managed to do good while under Prime’s control. But it doesn’t change that I hurt people. Nothing will change that fact.

“Oh shoot, I am *so* sorry,” I say, holding pincers up to my face. “I really didn’t want to! I was just—”

Melog mews again and I stop hastily, looking to Catra expectantly.

She smiles and waves me closer. “It’s fine, Scorpia. C’mere.”

I approach slowly, clacking my pincers together nervously. Catra holds out one hand to me, the other on Melog’s back. I give her my pincer and she brings it closer to Melog. When my rock-hard exoskeleton makes contact with their nose, I feel a jolt of electricity up my arm. A brief glow encompasses us both. The sensation reminds me of when I first connected with the Black Garnet. That surge of power and warmth within me. Banishing away the doubts and insecurities that always lingered within me.

“Oh! Aren’t you a cutie!” Before Catra or Melog can say otherwise, I scoop Melog up into my arms for a good, ole

patented Scorpia hug. Melog yowls in protest for the briefest of seconds before allowing themselves to sink into the hug. An echoing purr vibrates against my exoskeleton. They sink into the cradle and excitedly paw at the air. Mission complete, I set Melog back down on the ground and smile.

Melog wraps around Catra's legs, tilts their head at me and mews quietly.

"Melog's says don't worry about the zap." Catra gives me a twitchy smile, setting a hand on their head and stroking them quietly.

I turn my grin to her. "I'm sorry for zapping you, too. Perfuma told me—"

"Don't worry about it. I probably deserved it." Catra scratches the back of her head. "So, uh, portrait hall and throne room are out. What's actually open here?"

I hold a pincer up to my chin while I think. "Well, you know, we really only just started clearing everything out so… the dining hall, I think. Are you hungry? They make great food here! Not everything is rectangular, too."

"Yeah, not really hungry. There were all these apples in Thaymor."

"Swift Wind was telling me about that!" I chuckled and continued down the hall. "Who knew horses like apples so much? And what's even the deal with apples anyway? Like the outside tastes different than the inside. It's so weird"

Catra glances at me sideways. "Hah, they didn't believe me when I said that, but they're better than dehydrated protein slaw."

We stop in a hallway covered in vines that reach around surrounding the domed ceiling and up through the windows high above. I pinch at some of the vines, revealing the mural of Micah embedded on the wall. His mage's staff in hand, a moon of

Etheria framing his cloaked figure. A pang of a memory washes through me. Being dragged in front of him, and knocked to my knees to get chipped. *Join us in Prime's light* .

My eyes still study the mural as I say, "That was pretty scary, huh? The whole battle thing."

Catra scratches Melog's head. "I wouldn't know. I was down with Adora in the Heart."

"You missed the whole thing?"

"I mean, by the time I got back up, She-Ra had unleashed the magic and the battle was over. I didn't see it."

"Oh, well that's probably good." I lean towards her and bump her with my elbow. "I mighta zapped you again if I saw you, huh?"

Catra sways with the bump, a faint grin on her face. "Who would've guessed you finally had princess powers."

Melog pivots in front of her and rubs their shoulder affectionately against her leg.

"I know! Pretty crazy right? I'm still getting used to them." I hold up my pincers and two short zaps of red light bursts from their points. "Anywho, did you see the war room? It's pretty cool! They have this hologram and it has this map. We were using it to track the—I mean, they had all this cool stuff on it!" I lead onward further down the hallway. "I guess we're going to need to call it something else soon. Not much more war to fight! Everyone seems to be getting along so well." I snip open the doorway. This room seems to be devoid of overgrowth. The lack of windows might've helped. "Hey, this is cool! Check it out!"

I turn back and Catra stands uncomfortably in the doorway, arm across her chest. Melog gives her another rub, and pushes her with their head into the room.

"You know, it's a funny story. I snuck in here when I first got to Bright Moon. They were so surprised when they noticed I was in here! You should've *seen* their faces." I chuckle at the recollection. "Who would've guessed I was so sneaky?"

Catra spares a glance up to me but looks down again. She steps closer to the central table, touches it. Her fingers remove a thin layer of dust, the polished wood beneath glistening in the daylight. "It's so weird being in here."

"I know, right? Where're the endless fire pits? Where're the spike traps and torture chambers? Man, the Horde stories were almost disappointing when I got here. I was *so* scared that it was going to be just terrible inside. I mean, I remember the Battle of Bright Moon when I was fighting Glimmer. You know I never really apologized for trying to punch her? Oh, I guess there was also that time I was going to drop her off that bridge... I should go talk to her." I pause and clack a pincer to my chin, wondering if I will have a chance to talk to Glimmer. She's so busy having her kingdom to run and all. "Anyway, it was so ugly on the outside, but I figured inside it'd be a little more scary. But nope!"

Catra drags a claw across the table and leaves a smooth cut in the edge. She opens her eyes wide, as though she wasn't aware of what she was doing until just now. She jerks her hand back.

"Oh, don't worry about that. They have some really good craftspeople here. They can fix anything! I broke so many things with my pincers when I first got here. They know me really well by now." I tap the back of Glimmer's chair, stationed at the head of the table. "They said that I'm getting a seat next! Being a princess and all. I just hope there's a place to put my tail." I pull it around and grasp it between both my pinchers. "Silly thing always getting in the way."

Catra looks down at the scar she left on the table, then back up at me. I see the faintest smirk on her face and I feel a little surge of joy. I might just be able to get her to feel a little better. "C'mon!

I gotta show you the barracks! Err… ‘rooms’ I guess they call them here.” I hurry off into the hallway with Catra in tow.

We traverse Bright Moon in silence. She usually likes to have a little time to reflect anyway. Catra glances over her shoulder as though to check if we were being followed. Our tour abruptly stops as Melog steps ahead of us, specifically blocking Catra. They start mewing rapidly, the noise echoing in the open halls.

“Wh—What’re they saying?” I rub my pincers together anxiously.

“They’re not—” Catra swipes a hand in front of her. “No, stop it. It’s fine.”

Melog continues to mew and stands, butting their head against her.

“Hey, quit it!” Catra’s tail stiffens and the hairs bristle. She’s about to pop.

I contemplate leaving the two of them. Clearly, they need to sort this out on their own. I swing my tail behind me and inch towards a nearby doorway to slip through. Then I spot that it’s covered in vines and wonder if I can cut through inconspicuously.

Melog stops mewing at Catra and turns to me. They prowl towards me. Catra watches them, eyes narrowing into a scowl.

“Hey, I don’t want to get in the way here. I just wanted to—” I hold my pincers up between me and Catra. The power of the Black Garnet was so easily accessed within me now. What happens when the two of them get mad?

Melog wraps around my legs and blocks me from backpedaling away further from Catra. They mew again.

“It’s okay, Scorpia.” Her voice is more reserved again. She sighs deeply and the scowl eases from her expression. She just looks tired now.

Melog continues to mew at her.

I glance between the two of them. “Are they mad?” Is she mad?

“No, they’re saying—” Catra scratches behind her neck. “They’re saying that I should be honest with you.”

“Abo—About what?” I feel another flutter through my chest. My stomach turns.

“That…” Catra glares at Melog briefly. They sit expectant of her answer, still wrapped around my leg, tail swishing on the floor. She looks back toward me. “Why is this so *hard* ?” She presses her palms against her eyes.

I reach down a pincher and Melog bumps their head into it affectionately.

“I wanted to have a break from Adora, all right?” Catra’s hands drop from her eyes, revealing the embarrassed blush hidden beneath. She crosses her arm over her body and looks off to the side. “She gets chatty when she’s nervous and I just can’t take it all day long. I just was acting sick to get a break.”

“Oh… so you didn’t want to hang out with me.” I feel the wind pulled from my sails and I am dead in the water. I look down, away from her. Had she even changed? Melog bumps my pincer hard, startling me.

“No! Not that.” Catra growls in frustration, rubbing a hand over her brow. “That isn’t what I—dammit!”

Melog mews again and rubs their shoulder against my thigh. They flick their tail and it bats against mine.

“This whole ‘telling the truth’ stuff sucks. Just so you know.”

I spare a glance back up at her and she’s glaring at Melog again. They mew in response.

Catra heaves out an aggravated breath before collecting herself. "Scorpia, okay—here's the deal. Adora… she's been talking to me non-stop about showing me Bright Moon all day. And I get why she's excited but… You know how Adora is. She gets an idea in her head and nothing you say can get through. It's been a bit too much for me and I don't want to tell her because she's going to get mopey if I do. So I just wanted to get away without hurting her feelings."

A small surge rises inside of me. Maybe she has changed. "Well, Perfuma and I have talked about this kinda thing and it's always better to tell someone. Just… don't be… Catra about it, when you do." I smile awkwardly at her.

She smirks, one of her fangs peeking through. "Yeah, I've been trying to do that. I also…" She takes another deep breath, her gaze dropping off to the side. "I wanted to hang out with you."

"You did?"

"Yeah, it's been a while and…" Her eyes flick up briefly to me, as though to check if I were still standing there. "We're friends. At least… we were and I'd… I'd like that again."

I dash across the room and snatch her up in a hug. "Yes! Absolutely! There's so much to tell you about and I really want to talk about Perfuma and all the stuff we've been doing since you've been gone and—!"

Catra pushes back at my shoulders, gasping for breath. "Could you…?"

"Sorry!" I unceremoniously drop her and she lands gracefully on her feet.

"It's all right." She brushes her disheveled hair from her face, recollecting herself. Melog pads over to her and nuzzles against her.

"I like the new hair, by the way! I gotta say, I was a little shocked when I first saw it and without the mask too, but I really think it works."

She smiles a little ruefully. "Thanks, Scorpia. Adora thinks she should cut her hair, too."

My brow furrows in consternation. "Adora without a hair poof? That just seems wrong."

Catra chuckles quietly, a wistfulness to her expression. "She'd look like an idiot."

A thought strikes me suddenly and hard and I gasp so loudly Catra yelps and jumps in surprise, fur bristling. "Wait! I need to take you to your room!"

"Uh… my room?" She looks at me in confusion. "I didn't know I had a room already."

"Well, I mean…" I scratch at the back of my neck and chuckle awkwardly. "It's Adora's, but like… both of yours now. Unless… you don't... Do you? 'Cause I heard—"

The blush in Catra's cheeks is turning a deeper red by the second.

"Just, c'mon. I'll take you there!" I snatch her hand in my pincer and drag her down the hallway. She doesn't protest. I come to the hallway of rooms and pause. "Right… which one was it… I think… This one!"

I snip open the vines that obscure Adora's room and crack open the door. Save for the blast holes, it's just like she left it. An open space with a canopy descending from the center over the small, hard cot within. The normal waterfall is currently not flowing, probably blocked by plants somewhere. Several of the crystals lay shattered on the floor. The vases that normally contained the plants adorning the walls are overcome with foliage that snake up the walls and out onto the balcony.

With a shove I push the door the rest of the way open with a protest of cracking vines. I gesture her inward and she follows, cowed but with a faint excitement buried in her expression. I pull back and shut the door, turning to Catra.

Oh, I can't wait.

"Stay right there and…" I look to the side, unable to hide my excited grin. "Close your eyes."

Catra scowls in trepidation. "Uh, why?"

"Because it's not a surprise if you're looking!"

"It's just a room, Scorpia. I don't see what—"

"Close 'em!" I point a pincer at her warningly.

"Fine." She closes her eyes and stands with her arms crossed, biasing her weight onto her right leg.

"You too Melog! No cheating."

Melog tilts their head at me, but closes their glowing blue eyes and lowers their nose to cover them with their paw.

I scamper over to the stash behind the bed tent. Catra taps her foot impatiently as I hurry back to her.

"Hold out your hands. No peeking."

"Scorpia…"

"Do it!"

She reluctantly holds out both hands with a resigned sigh, her eyes still squeezed shut. Melog mews, tilting their head in curiosity, but doesn't look.

I delicately drape it over her arms. "Okay, open 'em."

She slowly peeks her blue eye open. Then follows with the yellow one. She repositions her hands and holds the shoulders of her old jacket looking at it like a ghost had emerged from the long and distant past. Her mouth opens slightly.

"I was just… After you disappeared, we were roaming around the Fright Zone on a patrol before Prime started chipping everyone and I found this and stashed it with my stuff in the camp." I scratch the back of my head with my pincer. "Just in case you—you know—came back."

Her voice is hoarse and barely audible. "Scorpia…"

"Turn it around." I click my pincers together in excitement, watching her closely.

She glances up at me uncertainly before folding it in her hands and turning it over. The material spreads back out, revealing the pattern on the back. The golden snake eating its own tail, but now added over the shoulders—

"Wildcat," she says absently.

"What do you think?"

She is unmoved, a statue. I remember this. Is she going to yell? All the excitement within me drains away, replaced by instant regret and doubt. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to ruin it. I stitched the first letter on myself but I kinda…" I look down at my indelicate and clumsy pincers. "I kinda messed it up. But I got someone to help me with the others!"

Tears start to bud in the corners of her eyes and I see her body shudder.

"It's bad, I know. Maybe we can have one of the—"

Catra collapses forward and wraps her arms tightly around me. I feel the pinch of her claws digging into my back, her arms too short to reach all the way around. I'm stunned into stillness. I

hadn't… We'd never… There were so many times I'd hugged Catra but I've never felt her arms around me. Not like this. Slowly, afraid of breaking this moment like I'd broken so many other things, I envelope her with my arms and hold tight. Melog encircles our legs bringing us all together. She sobs in a way that I've never heard before. Like all the anguish she carried for the years under Shadow Weaver and Hordak finally let go. She struggles for breaths between her cries. I hold her. It's what I'm best at.

"Thank you, Scorpia," Catra says, her voice muffled where it was pressed against my chest.

"No biggie, Wildcat," I say.

She pulls away eventually, wiping away the tears from her face. She clutches the jacket to her chest and looks around the room as though a little disoriented. "This is all just Adora's room?"

"I know! Crazy right? And I thought Force Captain barracks were spacey."

Catra's eyes linger on the single shelf next to Adora's bed. On it is a paltry collection of trinkets and carving. A wooden, winged horse. A little figurine of She-Ra. Each toppled on their sides and covered in dust.

When she speaks, her voice is distant and pensive. "I don't really like it here."

"Well…" I put my pincers on my hips and think. "We can get the vines cleared away and it'll look better. I actually had them make me a bed like Adora's because the beds here are too squishy and I popped like five of them."

She casts a sideways smirk at me. "That's not what I meant." The smile fades from her face so quickly. She wanders further into the room toward the open balcony. The sunlight streaming in shines off the gold filigree on the jacket in her arms. "No... I mean that I tried so hard to fight my way in here and suddenly I'm inside. Just like that."

"Ooooh, that *is* weird, isn't it?" I follow her toward the balcony, glancing outside at the rolling hills of trees that were the Whispering Woods. "It took me forever to get used to it when I first got here. Everyone helped me, though. Especially Frosta. She's just great."

Catra rubs at her cheekbone. "When she isn't punching things."

I chuckle. "She's a little firecracker isn't she? Or is that ice cracker?"

"Scorpia, what…" She glances hesitantly at me out of the corner of her eye. "What was it like the first night you were here?"

"Kinda weird, I gotta admit." I nod, recalling those first days of confusion. "But the sleepovers helped. And no one was yelling at me or telling me that I'm a failure or that I—"

"I really was that awful to you, wasn't I?" Though she speaks the words quietly, they bring me to a fumbling halt.

I recover quickly and whap her on the back bracingly. "Pfft, you didn't *mean* it. It was just part of the job. Right?"

She clutches the jacket tighter to her chest. There's a lingering silence as though she is having a conversation in her head before she starts it. "We were both chipped."

"Yeah," I scratch the back of my neck, trying to rub away the ghost of the chip from my skin, "but it was for just a little bit."

Her eyes are trained on the floor in front of her, unfocused and wavering. "You know how Shadow Weaver and then Hordak all acted the same? Like they had power and they wanted you to know they had power?"

"Oh yeah, they weren't subtle about it."

"I wanted that," she says. "I thought if I kept fighting I could get there. And… Scorpia. I'm so…" When she raises her eyes to

me, they're filled with tears once more. Her voice breaks. "I'm so sorry."

"Hey, that's all in the past now." I set a consoling pincer gently on her shoulder. "It's okay."

She knocks my arm off and takes a step away. "No! It's not! It's not okay and I just…" She takes a deep breath, trying to collect herself. She still holds tight to the jacket. "Don't be Scorpia for a bit, please? I need to tell you something."

I'm befuddled but I nod and wait.

Melog curls around Catra's legs and she releases one of her arms from around the jacket to reach down and pet them. "Horde Prime was just like Hordak and Shadow Weaver but somehow worse. When I was on the Velvet Glove with Glimmer, I saw how bad it gets. Prime just had a bunch of clones to push around and abuse. It made me realize that it was how everyone has treated me, and that I was trying to be like them. And I was doing it to you. When I managed to run *you* off. I—"

"Hey, don't worry about it." I step forward again to console her, but she backpedals away, shaking her head.

"Would you *stop* ? It's horrible and I didn't know what I was doing and you were always there and *I'm so sorry.* " Her eyes clench shut around more tears. She sinks into a crouch, Melog wrapping around her protectively. They put their head on her shoulder, mewing softly while she shakes with sobs.

Tears rain from her cheeks and patter on the floor.

I hesitate, but I go to her and sit on the floor next to them. She's so small—so much smaller than she appears and acts. But it makes it easy to wrap my arms around her and Melog and pull them close. Her head falls into the nest of my shoulder, her short hair brushing against my neck. I feel her shake with her sobs, but I hold onto her.

"Catra, it's really okay," I say, rubbing her shoulder with my arm. "We both kinda screwed things up and now we get to fix it."

She hiccups slightly and pulls back enough to look at me in confusion. "Huh?"

"Just, Perfuma's been great and she's taught me a lot about being me. She's got this thing that she showed me about sticking up for myself and I felt really guilty that I didn't do that for you for a long time. I just wanted to make excuses 'cause you were just doing what you thought was best. And she made a lot of sense that it was bad for the both of us. But that doesn't mean I'm *mad* about it. You're *Catra* ." I give her a pointed squeeze. "I knew you'd come around."

She buries her head back into my shoulder but I feel one of her arms clench around me. "Thanks," she says. "For not giving up on me."

"Any time, Wildcat."

Technically, A Reunion

Chapter Summary

In the wake of the Battle for the Heart, Etheria has been healing and the explosive florification event has been cleaned up. With that completed, The Best Friends Squad is making good on their promise to bring back magic to the universe. Unfortunately they only have one interstellar craft and it refuses to leave without her chief mechanic, Entrapta. She hasn't been seen or spoken with since she departed to Beast Island with Hordak. With that conundrum, Scorpia has taken it upon herself to reach out to her friend. A reunion of the Super Pal Trio is long overdue.

But the Entrapta that arrives is not the same one that they last saw. And this seems to be more than something just a hug can fix. But maybe a friend can.

Chapter Notes

Scorpia has her work cut out for her. Something's happened to Entrapta and she is the best woman on Etheria to try to help. This is a prelude to our second novella An Error Trap. Our Entrapta POV fanfic that explores what it's like inside of the head of the most brilliant scientist in the universe. She goes through *quite* a journey!

Hey Entrapta! It's been a while. Well maybe. I don't know if you've been getting my video or my voice messages, or my pictures come to think of it. I thought maybe a text message would be good to send, too! It took me a while to write it until Catra agreed to help me so she's typing this right now! These are her fingers typing this. Oh, she's groaning right now. She's angry I'm making her write everything, but I don't want to miss any of this.

Anyway, things have been great in Bright Moon and Plumeria. We've managed to clear up most of the 'explosive florification' as you coined it. Well, except for Plumeria, we actually have tree skyscrapers! They're so big and tall.

Oh, Catra has just reminded me why we are sending this! See, Glimmer, Bow, Catra, Adora, and Micah are all preparing Darla for a new adventure! They figure there's bound to be planets that need the same kind of She-Ra magic and maybe they can start helping them. We actually got a call from the Star Siblings. They said you met them!

Sorry, sorry, you're right, Catra.

The important thing is that Darla has said she won't leave without you. So they're stuck unless you can get here. You must be really busy on Beast Island since you haven't been able to respond. Did the florification get there too? Must be a mess to clean up with the bots and whatnot. Adora says most of the scary things they told us in the Horde don't exist, but the pookas were pretty scary. They sound cute to me, but Bow insists they aren't. Maybe they're helpful now? You know, I just don't quite know.

Right, okay, sorry staying on track. We need you back here and we all would love to see you again. It's been so long and we need to catch up! I've been working on these plant machine things with Perfuma. Well, they're more like plants. But they grow stuff and they have these flowers that look like tiny gears and I want to show you!

Let me know if you get this!

Hope to see you soon!

-Scorpia & Catra

PS: Can you bring Emily, too? I really miss her.

PPS: Catra is saying this is the worst text letter ever. I disagree. And I'm making her type that.

Scorpia, I have received your letter and found it quite satisfactory in communicating the status of Bright Moon. I understand that Darla would not leave without me as I have extensive technical knowledge of her operations. I will see what I can do to convince her to depart, but I am afraid I must return to Beast Island afterwards. Please send a nautical vessel to meet me.

-Entrapta

"That was all she sent back?" Adora peers over my arm to look at the pad.

"Yup, but at least we get to see her again." A crest of a wave breaks on the dock of Seaworthy and scatters the briny mist at us.

Catra swipes her hand in front of her face with a sneer. "I don't see why we had to wait out here."

Adora raises a dubious eyebrow. "Maybe you shouldn't have gotten us kicked out of the tavern then."

"You're just mad you lost that arm wrestling match."

"I *did not* . I got distracted when *you* tried to—"

"Isn't this view amazing, guys?" I place a pincer on my hip and gesture outward with the other.

The ferruginous cliffs of Seaworthy rise behind us, descending down into open ocean. New ports have been carved into the rock wall, fresh wooden docks springing forth from the cliff-face. The protected entrance sheltered the inner city from an onslaught of waves in the winter months, but the destruction of Horde Prime necessitated some changes to the city. Open docks would be fine in the summer.

I side-eye Catra. She still wasn't wearing the jacket. I wonder why? She acted like it meant everything to her. But I suppose that's enough. Catra's gonna Catra.

Melog's tail gently thumps on the wooden dock. They look between us, blue glowing eyes full of concern, only to be interrupted by a spray provoking the most cutest and precious sneeze I have ever heard.

I nearly melt. "Awww! You sound just like Catra!" I hold my pincers in front of my face.

"They do *not* ." Catra huffs and crosses her arms.

Melog looks at me, startled. I resist the temptation to scoop them up into another hug. There's serious business to be attended to. And I need to attempt to be professional. In some way, at least.

The docks teem with life around us. People move cargo from ship to ship. More goods needed moved more quickly. Glimmer's kingdom was at the forefront of rescue and relocation to people displaced by the invasion. The Horde had scoured some of the smaller towns and cities off Etheria. Despite everything though, there is raucous joy all around us. Spirits are high after the clearing of the seaweed that had briefly overtaken their livelihoods. Now the seas are free again, and we could resume moving supplies across the world and helping those that are still isolated.

I take in a deep breath. "It's so gosh darn nice having the two of you here."

"And me!" Swift Wind adds from behind us.

Melog mews as well.

"Yes! You guys, too! I always knew we'd be standing here together. I mean maybe not Melog—I didn't even know there *was* a Melog. But I sure am glad that we're here together, finally. I

mean maybe not here, specifically. I wasn't picturing Seaworthy, but you know, somewhere. The togetherness part is really what I was picturing."

"Yeah. I guess it is." Adora smirks at me, and nudges Catra prompting a rueful grin.

I resist another temptation to snatch everyone up in a giant hug. "When the biggest problem we have is doing a little gardening, I think things are pretty A-OK!" For us anyway. I missed talking with Entrapta. Even if I didn't understand all the science thingies, her enthusiasm for her work made it hard not to be happy when she was around. I didn't really get a chance to see her after the battle at the Heart. With Hordak back, she hadn't really had time for anyone else and soon they left for Beast Island to get to work.

I only had a short goodbye with her. But that's okay. We were all so busy cleaning up Etheria, it was easy to let those things slip by. I'm just glad I could see her again now.

A sail crests the horizon. The purple radiance is unmistakable of a Salineas skimmer. I point with my pincer. "There they are!"

"Okay, you've said that a dozen times already, Scorpia." Catra huffs, ear flicking in annoyance. She's edged behind me and Adora to block the incoming spray from the waves.

"Yes, but I mean it this time! I recognize that sail! Kinda—I think." I was sure of it. In fact, only one sail looks like his. The rainbow of light is visible even from this far away. Mermista's ship-builders had taken a special craft to his vessel. "It looks different though." The triangular sails are more squared now. The profile is lower to the water.

Adora shields her eyes with her hand, squinting at the ship. "I wonder what the Dragon's Daughter count is up to now."

"Oh, oh! I'm guessing eight!"

She turns to me in shock. “Eight?”

I nod solemnly. “He lost a few during the invasion.”

Swift Wind pushes his head between us. “I don’t understand the point of ships. Why don’t people just fly everywhere? It’s much more fun.”

“Because not everyone has wings, idiot.” Catra steps aside to let him through.

Her attitude is strange. She’s been happy since the first couple nights back on Etheria—well, Catra happy. But now something feels different. Ever since she read Entrapta’s response, her mood has soured. She sure has been in an *extra* bad mood all day today. Maybe I can get her something nice at one of the merchants before we leave.

The skimmer glides through the azure water, cutting through the waves like a scalpel. On the bow of the ship, a very excited Sea Hawk waves. “Hello, friends!” He still wears his blue jacket and bright crimson bandana. His mustache is impeccably groomed as always, but his headband is a turquoise—the royal color of Salineas.

I wave back. “Hello, Captain Sea Hawk!”

“Don’t call him that,” Catra says.

“Why not?”

The boat stops with a thud as it collides with the dock, causing Catra and Melog to leap into the air. I resist the urge to catch her. Sea Hawk barely maintains his balance grabbing onto the bowspirit and dangling about the docks. He clambors back up.

“ *That’s* why,” Catra grumbles under her breath. She smooths out the poofed hair on her head and tail and shoots Sea Hawk a sharp glare. “You know you should’ve been steering.”

"And miss my dramatic entrance? Never!" He fixes his jacket and takes a dramatic pose, setting his boot on the bow, finger pointing in the air. "It was a daring adventure, but I have recovered our friend Entrapta from the perilous Beast Island!"

I hold my pincers nervously in front of my face. "There're still mean things wandering around on it?"

"No, it's quite nice actually." His pose dips briefly before he puffs his chest out. "Regardless! I shall return!"

"Well, good to see he hasn't changed a bit," Adora says under her breath.

"I know! Isn't it wonderful?" I click my pincers in excitement.

There's a shifting and scuffling on the deck of the boat just out of our sight. A large plank lifts into the sky and falls with a clatter onto the wooden dock. Sea Hawk stands at the side and bows, gesturing someone onward.

The dome of a spherical robot crests the rise and comes lumbering down the ramp. The wood groans in protest as Emily rolls the rest of the way to us. I catch her in my wide open arms. "Emily!"

She chitters with a chorus of chirping and beeping joy. She stands on her legs again and pushes into me. She looks a little different. Her face still bears the scratch marks from so long ago. Entrapta never wanted to fix those. Otherwise, she seems no worse for wear other than a dent on the top of her head. Must be tricky on Beast Island. If the stories I heard in the Horde were anything to go by...

"Hey, buddy! I missed you, too!" I pat the dome of her head and catch a smile from Catra out of my periphery before she straightens again and the expression falls from her face.

I follow her eyes to the deck of the ship.

The lilac pigtails rise first, then we see her face.

Something's wrong.

Maybe it's the long stare of emotionless eyes. Or the way she clutches her data terminal against her chest. Her muscles are taught, steps tentative, and her animate pigtails are as still as limp noodles. She slowly walks down the ramp.

Something is very wrong.

Melog mews softly, nudging Catra's leg.

"What's going on?" Swift Wind whispers, his head dipped toward Adora's ear.

"Maybe she's sea sick," she whispers back.

Emily turns back towards Entrapta and chitters. Entrapta smiles faintly.

"Hello, friends. It is good to… see you." Her reserved smile hurts more, somehow. Her pigtails hang limp beside her. All of the spark and joy has evaporated from her like… like a science thing. Like a cold cup of tea! Maybe I should say that. No, that'd be rude.

I pat Emily on the head. "Are you feeling okay, Entrapta?"

"Yes, the voyage was rather… long. Thank you sea-man for bringing tiny fish to eat." She turns to Sea Hawk with a wan smile.

"It's—ah, nevermind." He coughs and smiles brightly. "It was my pleasure. I am sorry that our journey was not full of *ADVENTURE* !" He sweeps his arm broadly back toward his vessel. "I am honored to have you aboard the maiden voyager of the Dragon's Daughter *X* !"

Adora snorts. "What happened to eight and nine?"

"Alas, the Dragon's Daughter VIII met her end with a great sea dragon released from the depths in the explosive florification event of She-Ra. She was such a fine vessel." He dramatically closes his fist in front of him and looks down. His grandeur is impeccable.

Catra glances at Adora and then back at him, eyebrow raised. "And number nine?"

Sea Hawk's grandiose posture deflates like air out of a balloon. "Mermista sank her"

"Doesn't she usually make those for you?" I pat the top of Emily's head as she pushes into me, still chittering but in a more forlorn tone.

"She does! But I asked the shipbuilders to put a figurehead of her on the bow. It was beautiful. So radiant in the sunsets of Etheria. But when she found out it was naked, all was lost in my lovely Mermista's fury." He slumps with arms drooping down as though he could sink into the dock.

There's a snicker that wafts through the group, but I don't hear Entrapta. Where did she go? A brief panic overcomes me. Had she fallen into the water? Can she swim? What if someone ran off with her? I blink and see her walking away from us with Melog in tow keeping pace with her. I see Adora spot her as well. She has the same concern, it seems.

"You should consider a horse for your next figurehead! What's more majestic than *this* ?" Swift Wind unfurls his brightly colored wings and tosses his head back so his flowing mane billowed in the wind. "And 'dragon's daughter' is a little… gauche, don't you think? Have you considered rebranding to—"

"Swift Wind, now's not the time! Just c'mon." Adora beckons him to follow her, nodding pointedly at Catra and me. "I'll go talk to her."

“Oh! Are we going to discuss the horse-friendly modifications I want to make to the ship? I have a lot of ideas that I would like to —” He trots after her, his enthusiastic voice fading behind the crashing of ocean waves and seagulls. They follow the lonely inventor shambling down the dock. Purple pigtails drape behind her. The workers moving their boxes between the different boats step carefully over her trailing hair.

Catra leans in, and Sea Hawk and I follow her lead. “Was she like this the whole way?”

“Indeed.” He twirls his mustache thoughtfully. “I even offered a shanty about bots and she would not join me.”

Catra snaps a glare at him. “Okay, the first mistake was the shanty.”

“My shanties are known to lift anyone’s spirits.” He steps back in indignation. “They’re world renown!”

“C’mon, Catra. I bet the one about the bots was really good!” I pat him on the back.

“Oh, it was!” He clears his throat and places his hand on his chest. “Ooooohhhhhhh, there once was a great bot that —”

The sharp sound of Catra extending her claws screeches the shanty to a halt. “Nope, not now. You keep going and I’ll throw you off this dock.”

He frowns and slowly drops his hand from his chest. “Some people just don’t appreciate good art.”

“Tell me about it! You know she won’t even let me demo any of my songs with her?”

Sea Hawk’s face is awash with sympathy for me. “Oh, that is a *crime* , Catra. Why would you—”

“Would you two idiots shut up?” she snarls at us.

Emily bumps into me again. I glance down at her and smile reassuringly. “Hey, it’s okay! We’re talking about her.”

She shoves and steps back. The three of us open our huddle to her. She pauses for a moment now that Catra has locked eyes with her sensor. She slowly moves again and gestures to her side, beeping rapidly. I’d gotten pretty good at interpreting her beeps, but I didn’t quite understand what she was trying to tell me now.

“You know, I don’t remember her leg sticking quite like that.” I touch a pincer to my lips, brow furrowing. “And that dent is new.”

There’s a threatening growl from Catra. Her voice is low and dangerous. “Was Hordak there when you picked her up?”

“No. Come to think of it, it was just her and that bo—” He stops when Emily’s optical sensor narrows at him. “I mean Emily.”

Emily’s dome dips, gesturing her gratitude.

“Right. Scorpia—” Catra snaps like the crack of a whip.

The bark of my name draws me back towards her. I recognize that look. The one of the Horde so long ago. I have a brief lapse of fear, but her expression is different. Determination, not anger. “Yeah?”

“She’s coming with us.”

“But her note said—”

“I know what her note said, and I don’t care. Something is going on.” She looks to the side, staring down some unknown threat.

Sea Hawk points his finger upward. “I do believe that she needs something to lift her spirits. If a shanty cannot do it, then perhaps an *adventure* in the open *space* ?” He jabs the sky to emphasize the epicness of his idea.

Catra pinches her nose. “Sure fine, whatever, but Scorpia you need to convince her to leave on Darla with us.”

I blink twice at her. “Me? Why me?”

She crosses her arms and looks at me sidelong. “Because you’re annoyingly persistent at getting people to like you and feel wanted.” She turns her glare out toward the ocean and grumbles almost as an afterthought, “Trust me, I know.”

“Oh… I… I don’t know.” There’s a rush of warmth in my cheeks.

“Nonsense, Scorpia!” Sea Hawk throws an arm over my shoulders, flexing an arm over his chest. “You are the perfect choice for this mission!”

Sea Hawk and Catra watch me expectantly. Something rises in my chest—they really had confidence in me, didn’t they?

“Can you do it?” Catra asks.

I salute her. I look down at Emily. Somehow despite having only three limbs and an orb for a body, she reflects her concern.

“You stay here buddy.” I pat her on the head again.

She looks down, a little diminished, but she doesn’t move when I turn away to jog off to Adora and Swift Wind who are walking back. Entrapta sits on the dock behind them, still clutching her data terminal tight. Alone except for Melog who hasn’t left her.

“What happened?” I ask.

“I don’t know.” Adora shakes her head and shrugs. “We tried talking to her.”

“I even offered her carrots. They have *real* carrots here and she didn’t want any.” Swift Wind clicks a hoof for emphasis.

"If she doesn't want carrots then something must really be wrong." I scratch my chin with my pincer.

"She wanted to be left alone for a minute." Adora spares a look over her shoulder back at Entrapta. "I'm worried about her."

"Us too. Catra told me I need to convince her to go with you guys."

Adora blinks as she processes what I just said. She focuses again, the same determination I saw in Catra in her eyes. "Can you do it?"

"I don't think this will be solved with a hug, but I'll do my best." I hold my pincers up and shrug, but the gesture slips from me into a slump. They all had so much confidence in me. So much expectation. I just wasn't sure if I deserved any of it.

Adora places an affectionate hand on my shoulder and I feel my doubts slide away. "You got this, Scorpia."

I smile appreciatively. I *can* do this. I straighten my back and walk towards Entrapta with a long stride. My courage diminishes as I get closer. An aura of melancholy lingers around her. She sits on the dock, legs kicking over the water. She still clutches her data terminal in her lap, chin resting on the top.

Melog looks at me with eyes full of concern and turns back to Entrapta.

I walk up behind her. "Hey, Entrapta. You doing okay?"

"Yes, all functions are optimal. Why do you ask?" Each word sounds more robotic than a… a robot's really.

"I dunno. Something seems wrong." I slowly take a seat next to her, minding her long pigtails that rest on the dock around her. I curl my tail back away from the walking dock workers. Another accidental sting could cause quite a ruckus.

"I haven't been able to detect any abnormalities." Her words are far away—she might as well still be on Beast Island.

Maybe I can get through to her with something. "Oh, okay… well how great is it to have the Super Pal Trio back together, huh? I mean, you and Catra were on Darla together and all that and I was chipped for a bit and after that everyone's been so busy but *now!* Oh-ho. Now we're all together again. Isn't that great?"

She stares unfocused off to the horizon. "It is nice to see familiar faces again. I believe it is a serotonin inducer that brings back nicer memories. How has D—"

Excellent! A connection! "Oh, I've been great! I've been with Perfuma in Plumeria helping out there. Before that, Bright Moon. I've just been helping out wherever I can! Now that there isn't a Horde or a Rebellion anymore, I'm just kind of wherever anyone needs me."

She strains a smile at me. "That is good to hear. I was inquiring about Darla's operating status, though."

There's a cold flush down the back of my neck. This is going to be harder than I thought. "Oh, Darla! She's good… I think… You know, I don't really know? Bow and the others are the ones that have been working on her and coming up with all the plans. I just came along to see you!"

"I appreciate the thought. I was… hoping to see you. But… actually I did it for Emily." She kicks her feet over the ocean. A wave of water rushes in and splashes against the pilings below us.

I match her kicking with my feet. Another wash of mist bursts up towards us. "Well, whatever Emily needs. She looks just great you know! Does she still play fetch?"

"She does." Entrapta rallies herself with shallow breath. "Scorpia, I would like to ask a favor of you." Her voice crackles like fresh snow crunching under a boot.

"Of course! Anything." I swing my pincer in front of me and clack it for emphasis.

"When I go back to Beast Island, could you keep Emily here?" She still won't look back over at me.

I pause. I've never seen her like this. How could she ask me to look after Emily? I mean, I will. There's no question that I will. But why? I never thought Entrapta would willingly leave Emily's side. "Of course, no doubt! But won't she miss you?"

"Oh, yes. It will take time for her cognitive logical processes to recover, but I'm afraid she is a little disruptive of Hordak's—I mean *our* work." She bites her lip. Somehow her pigtails dangle even more limply.

"Oh, I'm so sorry to hear that." A weight falls in my stomach. It pulls me in like a gravity something or other towards a sadness that effuses all around her. This must be what Catra meant. "Why don't you stay so she doesn't have to miss you so much? I mean, are you sure you want to go back to Beast Island? Not just for her, but all of us. We've all missed you here, Entrapta. You could stay a little longer."

"Hordak and I—I had to leave in the middle of an important project. He needs me back as soon as I can manage." Her voice is dry, as distant as her thoughts.

I raise a pincer to my chin. "Well… you know… Hordak can come, too. I haven't seen the big lug since the Heart! How's he been since She-Ra zapped Horde Prime outta him?"

She smirks sardonically. "Oh, he wouldn't come. There's just… he's really focused right now. It would be nice to bring him, though. I think he'd like the infinite vacuum of space. But maybe he's been there too much. It doesn't matter. I need to get back soon." She sets her data terminal beside her. The midday light catches in the shining blue eyes of her mask and casts two bright dots on her forehead. In place of her terminal, she interlocks her

fingers and rests her hands on her lap. Her legs still kick over the side.

"I know he's doing that whole… 'making up for what did' thing by cleaning up Beast Island, but you guys can take a break for this right? Come to think of it, how is that making up for anything? I mean, I guess bots have feelings too and there were some scary things on there but…" Her kicking has stopped, her body rigid. Something about what I said is too disruptive. I don't want to hurt her. "He doesn't have to come if he doesn't want to. But I still think *you* should go. I think everyone could really use your help on Darla. What could be more important than bringing back the magic to the universe?"

She turns to me. Her expression shows a pain behind a stony veil.

It's the first time that she's looked at me and it's like she's a different person. Her eyes that normally sparkle with joy and energy are quiet and flat. Disconnected and disinterested in what was around her. This isn't the Entrapta that I know.

I can't dance around the subject anymore. Perfuma says that sometimes the best way to confront something was to face it head on.

"You know Darla won't leave without you, right?"

She looks down and shakes her head. Her pigtails loosely follow the motion. "No, I should be able to convince her. Her operations are much more stable now that she's had time to mend her own systems."

"That probably doesn't matter much to her. She said you're the only person that she trusts to 'operate' on her. Her words, not mine." I emphasize my honesty with a pincer over my chest.

There's an almost fragile look in Entrapta's eyes when she turns to me again. "She did?"

"Well, yeah! Of course. Who else would she ask for?" I smile. Maybe that's headway?

She blinks and the brief glimpse of joy falls away. "That was very nice of her, but—"

Her mood is so delicate that it scares me a little. But I can be brave. "Catra asked for you, too."

Entrapta swallows. "I've ascertained that lots of individuals have been asking about me."

"Of course! We miss you. We've been completely lost with some of the tech we've recovered." I make a fumbling gesture with my pincers as though I could connect two wires together.

I catch a brief smile from her.

This feels right. I press further. "Maybe it's time to take a break from Beast Island. I think Hordak would be fine. And maybe… maybe there's some cool new tech out there or you can help people out in ways only you can. I mean, you saved us all from being chipped! Imagine what you could do when there *isn't* a crazy clone army trying to kill all of us."

She looks down, back towards the sea. "I did find those problems to be quite enjoyable to solve. I certainly didn't get to work on anything like that on Etheria. But…" The brief brightness of enthusiasm in her fades. "I don't know…"

I bite my lip. "I think I know something else you could work on, too."

She pulls a pigtail forward and rests her chin on it. She plays with a small shell that rests on the dock, flipping it over and over with her heavy glove. "What's that?"

"Why not work on your friendships?"

She doesn’t look up, only keeps worrying at the white fidget on the weathered wood. “I don’t see the point of that scientific inquiry. They seem to be fine without me. I’m not sure what more data there is to gather there.”

I scooch a little closer, using my tail for additional help. “That’s not true! Think about it. You started with just me and Catra, and then you made friends with all the princesses. There are so many people out there in the universe, Entrapta. And I’m sure they’d all be happy to meet you and get to know you. You’re one special gal.”

“I believe in your earnestness, but I’m unclear if your data is biased or not. I don’t think I am very good with friends.” She sounds so far away like she was trying to talk with me from another kingdom.

“And you think I am?” I bump Entrapta with my elbow.

She is unmoved. She pokes the seashell again and the umbrella shaped object flips into the air, nearer to the edge of the dock. “Well, yeah. When I met you and Catra, you two already had an established social dynamic that you made me a part of. Of course you are capable of functional and enjoyable friendships.”

“Ah.” I remember when we found her in the vents. She just fell into our laps. The nicest and most reasonable prisoner we ever caught. “Funny thing about that. I didn’t really know what being a friend was, either.” I spare a glance out to the water. “I don’t think *anyone* knows how to be a friend right away. We all need to learn how to be one. Perfuma sure knows a lot. She always has good ideas about peace and calm. But I bet even *she* had to learn.”

Entrapta stops poking at the shell and turns towards me. “I can’t understand how the chlorokinesis princess would have difficulty with her social interactions. I don’t know of any individuals that could dislike her. But your point has piqued a curiosity. Could you explain your logical derivations further?”

"Oh sure, you know… I mean when Catra… and she…" I push my claw forward and make a *zzzt* noise.

Entrapta stares at me. She nods, but doesn't say anything.

"Yeah, when she did that—after she did that, I kept trying to stick up for her. But I wanted to get you back, too. And I kind of… I screwed up, Entrapta. I was confused, and a little scared. So much was happening so fast and I didn't do anything." I lean back and prop myself up on both of my pincers. The sun sinks toward the horizon, casting a rufescent glow among the waves. "I let you down. And then I tried to make it better in the *worst* way possible. I thought I could convince Catra that she was wrong, but I was the wrong one. I figured it out later… too late. I was afraid. And I didn't stick up for you when I realized I should have."

"Oh, that's all right. Lots of things happened then." Her words are more natural. "The chaotic patterns of everyone's behaviors were very hard to discern in a logical way."

A tingling sweeps up my back and into my cheeks. "You make it sound simple."

"Well, it was. I wound up on Beast Island because I thought I could trust…" The thought dies in the wind of Seaworthy.

"See why I'm saying this friendship thing is hard? *I* screwed it up. And I had to learn from it. And I think it's kind of like you say. *Science is never wrong* . And having friends is kind of like a science. Isn't it? Like you do things, little experiments, and you see how people react."

"Yes, but the data is so *unreliable* ." A small, exasperated emotion slips into her voice.

"Oh, tell me about it!" I smile and lean toward her. "But you know what's neat about it?"

"What's that?"

"I think it's the only science you can't do by yourself. You need people to look at the data with you and help you figure out what things mean. That's why I'm so glad I met Perfuma." The thought of her makes me smile and I turn back toward the sea. "So, maybe if you go on Darla, you can run some experiments with people up there. Friendship experiments. And get some new data. And maybe… maybe things will be better."

A tear drops from Entrapta's face. She doesn't bother covering it. She doesn't pull away. She sits there silently on the dock. I gently place a pincer behind her, and she leans into me.

"Okay," her voice cracks. "I think running some new experiments might be good for me."

"Great." I give her a small squeeze. "Why don't you report back to me with the results, huh? I can be your science buddy on this one."

"I'd like that." Her words are so tiny.

Melog ends their silent vigil behind us and finally trots alongside. They curl up next to Entrapta and she reaches out a hand to stroke their fur.

"Hey, I'm sorry, by the way."

"For what?" Her weight is miniscule against my pincer. Her pigtails wrap around it where the point meets the dock.

"For the whole Beast Island and Portal mess and not coming to get you sooner. I just wanted to say that."

She scratches Melog behind their ears and they yawn. She doesn't look at me, but pats my shoulder with one of her pigtails.

"I forgive you."

The Wings She Carried

Chapter Summary

While searching for Perfuma, Scorpia finds an Adora with a lot on her mind. Adora holds in her hand a brand new Bright Moon medallion. The question? Should she give it to Catra?

Thankfully, Scorpia is the perfect person to ask.

Chapter Notes

This is a repost of the Interlude that precedes our third novella Adora's A Door to our Hearts. Adora's got a lot of feelings to explore and a lot of trouble she's faced. Now is the time to open those up, and see what lurks within. Scorpia is on the job to get that started.

We like sharing it here for our Scorpia fans that are following along in her story so they don't miss anything. :)

It's another bright and pleasant afternoon in Bright Moon as I make my way down the edificial halls. The typical trill of birdsong and music that adorned the halls is drowned out by hammers and chisels working away at the stonework. The masons are busy filling in the cracks and divots scarring the castle from the war and the explosive florification with a mixture of stonedust and magic. An ancient technique in Etheria that didn't remove cracks, but instead filled them in with beautiful iridescence. Like thin strands of starlight set into stone.

"Lookin' good!" I say as I pass by the masons. "Keep it up!"

Some pause to wave at me, but most of them are too focused, too dedicated. Everyone wants to heal Etheria in their own way after the war. For some, that means sealing in cracks in the infrastructure. For She-Ra, it meant zapping everything with plants. As Perfuma always says: the universe has a way of healing itself.

I come to the war room—the *planning* room, I mean. There's no need for a war room anymore, but there is certainly a lot of relief efforts and reconstruction projects to plan. It's a much more fitting name. I peek my head inside and see Queen Glimmer standing over the holographic display with Bow at her right hand and General Juliet at her left. The general clutches her helmet beneath an arm while she points at parts of the hologram with the other. She hasn't had much occasion to wear her helmet recently.

"The reports from Erelandia say the relief mission was a success. The plants have been cleared and the citizens have been able to resume normal activity. On top of that, harvests are looking good for this year."

"Great!" Glimmer says. "Any word back from Frosta yet?"

"Not yet, Your Majesty."

"We should move focus to opening up the mountain passes to Dryl then." Bow zooms in on the mountains leading to Dryl. Geometric triangles represent the spires of the castle against the sloping ridges. "With Entrapta busy prepping Darla, they'll need our help."

Glimmer lets out a long breath before gathering herself again. "That's a good idea Bow. General, send the orders."

"Right away, Your Majesty." General Juliet salutes and starts for the door. She draws up short when she notices me standing at the doorway. An old reflex, I'm sure, but her hand goes to where she usually wears a sword before she regains herself. "Excuse me, Princess."

I wave a pincer and smile. "Hey guys. Sorry. Didn't mean to disturb you there."

"Scorpia!" Bow's brief look of surprise quickly turns into a smile. "We didn't notice you."

Glimmer waves the general on before smiling at me as well. I can't help but notice the fatigue dimming her usually bright eyes. "How long have you been standing there?"

I hedge a little farther into the room. "Oh. Not long. I've just been on a walk, thought I'd pop in."

"That sounds wonderful." Glimmer turns her gaze forlornly back to the holographic display. "I've been stuck in here *all* day."

"Been working hard, huh?" I put my pincers on my hips and examine the display. There are several red pins scattered across the kingdoms, marking areas still paralyzed by the explosive florification or the lasting effects of Horde Prime's invasion. "Oh wow! Look at all that progress. Last time I was in here there was a lot more red."

"We're getting it done. Slowly but surely." Glimmer exhales wearily and sets her hands on the table. "Etheria will be back to normal soon."

"Well, what even *is* normal, you know?"

Bow and Glimmer glance up at me in confusion, sending a short jolt of panic through me.

I rub a pincer behind my neck. "I just mean with the magic released and the Horde gone and the wars over, Etheria is different from how it's been for a long time. Like, do we even know what a normal Etheria is supposed to look like?"

Bow taps his chin in thought. "That's a good point. So much has changed even since Mara's time. Maybe I should ask my dads for what Etheria was historically like. They might have something in that library…" He takes out his tracker pad and quickly types out something on it.

Glimmer groans and finally collapses into the seat behind her, slumping over the hologram so her forehead hit the table. "Great. Even after everything…" She let out a groan like when someone

picks up something too heavy for them before I can help them out. "I just wanted things to go back to how they should be."

"Well, I don't think it's a bad thing it's all changed!" I gesture over my shoulder, where the halls echo with the sound of masonwork. "I love what they're doing out there—with that sparkly stone paste thing? It's beautiful! It's different from how the halls looked before, but I think it looks better."

Glimmer tilted her head in thought, her eyes on the doorway. A wistful smile came across her face. "My mom always said the same thing. I haven't really looked at the progress around Bright Moon yet, but maybe I'll take a break and walk around."

"That's what I've been doing and, lemme tell ya, it's pretty great. You have a beautiful kingdom."

Bow grins warmly at Glimmer and sets a hand on her shoulder. She straightens and smiles. "Thanks, Scorpia."

I feel rather proud of myself. It's not every day you get to cheer up a queen. "No problem! It's like Perfuma always says—don't dwell on the negative. Look at the positive. Oh! Speaking of, have you guys seen Perfuma around? We had some plans but I can't seem to find her anywhere."

Glimmer shakes her head but Bow says, "I think she's with Catra. Something about unlocking her… chalk art?"

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "Chakras?"

He snaps his fingers and points at me. "Yup! That's it. Whatever *that* is."

"Oh good! You know, now that you mention it, I remember her saying something about helping Catra today." I chuckle and shrug. "Silly me. Guess I forgot."

"Bow, I don't think I can stare at this hologram a second longer." Glimmer stands and laces her arm through his. "Let's take

that break."

"Okay." He smiles at her before turning back to me and saying, "I think they're out on the garden balco—" They disappear with a flash of sparkles before he can finish the sentence.

I stand for a moment glancing around the planning room, wondering if I'm supposed to secure it before I leave. But the thought is silly. Something left over from the war. So I shrug and walk out, continuing down the halls amid the symphony of the masons working and the warmth of the sunlight.

I arrive at the garden balcony. Though the worst of the florification has been cleared away at this point, the topiary is still overgrown and towering, overtaking much of the normally open and clear garden. The sun is starting to set, painting the horizon a deep red, fading to a soft pink at the farthest reaches of the sky. It casts streaks of pearlescent light like a painter took a giant brush and stroked it from horizon to horizon. A wandering flock of birds floats on a estival breeze among the glowing motes of magic within the air.

Perfuma and Catra are nowhere in sight out here. Well jeez, I'm really running out of places to look for them. Maybe it was time to call it and just wait in our room for whenever Perfuma was done. But then I notice her.

Standing at the topmost tier of the balcony with her back to me, overlooking the lower tiers of the garden down into the sparkling river valley, is Adora. She is hard to miss in her usual red jacket, with her blonde hair pulled back in her ponytail. The hair poof seems extra poofy against the setting sunlight. She leans her elbows against the railing, one boot crossed behind the ankle of the other. Her head is tilted downward as she studies something in her hand rather than the beauty of the scenery around her.

The sight is almost startling. I haven't seen Adora alone since the war ended. She's always off with Glimmer or Bow or Catra, providing the services of She-Ra whenever and however she

could. Always running around doing something. That's just Adora. Even during the war, I hadn't ever seen her stand so still.

Maybe she knows where Perfuma and Catra are. It seems rude to ask right now. Whatever she's doing, she looks like she's concentrating super hard, but it couldn't hurt to ask, right? I come up behind her and pause. I hate this part. She's distracted, and I can't draw her attention without startling her.

Maybe if I'm extra soft…

I clear my throat. "Hey, Adora…?"

She jumps upward like a shock of my Red Garnet lightning just zapped up her legs. The small bauble she holds scatters up into the air. She panics, reaching up wildly to catch it. It bounces from her fingers once, twice. She dives forward for it, slamming her waist into the balcony and stretching over it, before finally snatching the bauble on its way down to the gardens below. Her balance teeters on the precipice, then she tips forward. I catch her by the boot before she can topple face-first over the edge of the railing.

"Whoa—I gotcha!" I pull her back to her feet.

"Scorpia!" Adora places a hand on her chest to calm herself. "You scared the shit outta me."

"Sorry! Sorry! I was just… I didn't know how to…" I try to cobble together words but can't find any appropriate for the moment. "I just had a question for you. Didn't mean to startle ya."

She sits back on the railing behind her and glances at her hand still clenched in a fist around whatever she'd nearly dropped. A quiet relieved breath. "It's okay. I wasn't paying attention. Caught up in my thoughts, I guess."

"A quiet moment to yourself, eh?"

“Yeah, something like that,” she says distractedly. She forcibly pulls her focus to me. “Did you need something?”

“I was just looking for Perfuma.”

Adora turns and leans her elbows back against the rail. “She and Catra are still at it.” There’s an undertone to her voice that I can’t quite place. Maybe she’s still recovering from nearly falling.

I join her at the railing. A wind rustles through the trees below, the sound reminiscent of its moniker, the Whispering Woods. I watch a flock of birds pass by on their way to a distant waterfall. “The whole crickets thing?”

“No, those are bugs.” Adora scrunches up her eyes as she tries to find the right word. “I think it’s supposed to be catwalks.”

“Well, that doesn’t seem right. Why would Catra need help with those?”

“No idea. Perfuma just said they needed straightening and it would take a lot of focus so maybe I should go on a walk or something.” She shrugs and looks down where she holds her clasped hand with the other. An extra layer of protection for whatever lays within. “I guess she has a lot of them because they’re still working on it. They’ve been at it for hours.”

I push off the rail and turn to look back at the castle where I was sure Perfuma and Catra were somewhere. I know how long meditation could take, but it doesn’t make it any easier to wait. “Well shoot. Perfuma and I were gonna get to the end of Mer-Mysteries: The Tide Also Rises today. I wanna know what happens to Sebastian…”

Adora lets out a breathy laugh, still distracted. “Mermista got you into those books, too?”

“Eh, not really. I’m more of a romance reader myself.” I touch a pincer to my chest and shrug. “But Perfuma likes them and I like them a lot more when we read together.”

“I got that one copy sitting on my shelf in my room. I haven’t had the chance to sit down and read it.”

I can’t help but chuckle. “Well, you should give it a try whenever you get a chance. I think you'll like something in there."

“I’ll check it out sometime.” She nods absently, her tone distinctly noncommittal. She unclenches her hand and turns a small golden object between her fingers. “How are you and Perfuma, by the way? I haven’t really gotten to see much of you two.”

“Oh, Perfuma is just great. She’s so wonderful and understanding and I just—” I sigh and lean onto the railing, resting my cheek against my pincer. Just thinking about her sends a flutter through my chest that I don’t think I’ll ever get used to. “I don’t know what I did to deserve her.” I blush when I realize what I’ve just said and I’m not sure if it’s okay to say these things. I’ve never really had anyone to say these things about before. Maybe I should apologize, but the words die in my throat.

Adora is smiling at me. Her eyes drift out across Etheria toward the glowing horizon. A level of thoughtfulness enters her voice as she says, “You deserve love too, Scorpia. I’m glad you and Perfuma are happy.”

“So happy!” I toss my arms into the air to help illustrate exactly the breadth of that happiness. “Like, growing up, I didn’t know that someone could be this happy, you know?”

She nods slowly, the smile vanishing from her lips, still turning over the golden trinket in her fingers.

“Wasn’t easy finding reasons to be happy in the Horde, was it?” I settle my forearms back against the rail and look out across the Whispering Woods. The same woods I journeyed through with Emily to come here, to Bright Moon. How terrified I was. How determined. So much has changed since then. “I think leaving the Horde was the hardest thing I ever did.”

Adora chuffs a harsh laugh. “Tell me about it.”

I glance at her sideways, noting an imperceptible weight that seems to drag her shoulders downward. “You know, it took a long time for me to wake up happy again.”

“Somehow, I don’t believe that.” She smirks slightly, throwing me a quick glance before focusing back on the bauble. “You always seemed so… chipper. Even during the worst of the invasion.”

“Yeah, I know.” I let out a sigh and lean a little harder on my forearms. On the garden tiers below us, a group of children play tag between the towers of the topiary. Not a care in the world to disturb their rambunctiousness. “I always try to be happy outside even when I don’t feel it inside. Every morning, I’d wake up and breathe in a new day and push down doubts and insecurities. It can be… exhausting honestly.”

Adora studies me, the golden object in her hand momentarily forgotten, a deep furrow to her brow. The expression sends a wave of doubt through me and I immediately backpedal.

“What? Did I say something weird? Jeez, I’m sorry. I do that sometimes.”

“No… just…” She shakes her head slowly and drops her eyes to hands again. “Waking up happy. I’ve never really tried to do that before. There were a lot of mornings when I could have used that. I wonder…” Her words falter and she clutches the curio tightly in a fist before letting out a long breath. She looks like a woman who has arisen from a fight, scarred but victorious. Burdened beneath an unshakable weariness.

She needs some cheering up.

“I think you did great! It might’ve been hard but you got us up and moving. Shoot, sometimes we were just trying to keep up.” I chuckle and nudge her with an elbow. “You made it easier to wake up happy. At least for me. We were afraid that you’d give up

sometimes—you took on so much. More than we should've let you, but we always trusted in you. And good thing we did, huh?" The memories burn like dry ice, but I try not to shy away from them. Perfuma always said there is strength in adversity, and I want to keep hold of that strength. "I'm glad it's over. Things are quieter again."

Some of the tension has eased from Adora's expression and she smiles wanly at me. "I like the quiet," she says.

"Me too." I return the smile. Still got it.

We let ourselves exist in the quiet for a moment. It's not a traditional quiet—it's actually quite noisy. The laughter of the children playing below, the roaring of the waterfalls across the way, the wind through the woods. The evening was anything but quiet, but it harmonized with the quiet within. Inner peace. That's what Perfuma called it anyway.

"Scorpia." Adora looks down and clenches her fist around the bauble, whites of her knuckles bearing, before relaxing again. "Are we… friends?"

"What?" I nearly fall over, the question taking me completely off guard. "What kind of question is that? Of course we are!"

Adora wears a muted smile. "I know. You and Perfuma are friends with everybody. But… not like that. Not in that way. I don't mean like *sure* we hang out together and aren't actively trying to kill each other anymore." She laughs a little awkwardly. "I suppose all of Etheria kind of counts by those standards." A pause as she turns over the trainket. "No, I mean it like… like we share something."

"Well, we shared lots of things!" I tap my pincer on the rail as I list them off. "We were both in the Horde. We were both Force Captains. Remember sitting in the briefing room? Oh man, I gave you so much crap about your hair." I laugh at the memory and resist the urge to bop her hair poof right now.

Adora shifts her weight, locking her boot behind an ankle again and clutching her elbows with her hands. She bites her lip, as though debating saying something.

"Oh shoot, that was the Portal thing, wasn't it?" A hot flush washes over my cheeks. "That was so confusing, wasn't it? It's hard to remember."

"Nevermind." She shakes her head and pushes off from the rail. "It's not important. I was just—"

"Catra."

She freezes mid-step before she can walk away. Her hands are two taut fists at her sides. She turns halfway back, looking up at me with a mixture of confusion and a surprising anger.

I guess I probably look the same right now. A weight lands firmly in my chest. I already regret using her name. I never… I didn't want to… There's so much to say and I never wanted to say it. I calm myself. I close my eyes and take in a deep breath. I hear Perfuma. Her words. *Take in the good air, and push out the bad. Purify your thoughts, your mind, and your soul.*

I meet Adora's eyes again. She hasn't moved, still standing uncomfortably that half-pace away. It bleeds into the air around us.

I need to fix this.

The words don't come easily and I fidget. Alternately setting my pincers on my hips, before dropping them, before scratching behind my neck. This is somehow harder than it was with Catra. More complicated. A conversation I never really thought I would have, and maybe part of me wanted to avoid. But I can't ignore it now—I won't. "I… We both… Catra's hard, isn't she? And she…" I look at Adora again and the words stop.

Pain. It's painted across her expression. I've seen her face down an army of soldiers from both sides. I even recall from the haze of

the chip her intransigent determination while fighting her. She never looked scared, she never looked… lost. But now? She was ready to shatter like a dropped porcelain dish.

I take in a deep breath. "She hurt both of us. And we both had to deal with that."

There's a tear, a single one in the corner of her eye. A long breath escapes her, seeming to take the strength out of her. She backs into her rail, hugging her arms around herself and looks up at the sky. The first traces of stars are just beginning to pierce through the intensity of the sunset. I want to scoop her up and swaddle her until she forgot about it all. A good hug could fix anything. But not right now. Personal space, Scorpia. Personal space. Now was the time for words.

"Adora… you…" I struggle to sort through the mess of feelings in my chest, lingering thoughts from days long past. "You left, right? And then Shadow Weaver assigned me with Catra and then Entrapta and I thought… I thought a lot of things about Catra in the Super Pal Trio. And I thought I could do better than you. I thought maybe that Catra just needed a special kind of attention —that maybe we could fix things. I thought maybe you gave up on her too easy and I could change her."

"Scorpia…" Her words are distant and cold as though they came right out of the Kingdom of Snows.

"No, listen…" I start pacing, my nerves channeling into my legs. I know this isn't coming out exactly right, but I have to say it. "I was wrong. You… you did the right thing. With Catra. She… I didn't realize it soon enough, or just maybe I ignored it for too long. Not until things were so bad and I had to lie about it to everyone and… and myself. I had to lie to make myself happy."

Adora is an immobile statue that I only notice in my periphery while I pace. It's probably better this way. I think if I look at her right now, if I see whatever was in her expression, I'll lose all courage to continue saying what needs to be said.

"Maybe it's just how we were taught in the Horde, but I thought that was the way things were and if I just kept going it'd make everything okay with Catra. But it didn't. It only got worse, and I let it get worse until I couldn't let it anymore. I had to leave. But I didn't just need to walk away from the Horde, or Catra, or go face the princesses."

My pacing stops and I face Adora again. She's listening, though her eyes are still fixed on the sky. Sensing my stillness, she drops her gaze to mine, an unwavering empathy within it. Maybe if she looked at me any other way, I wouldn't have continued.

"Honestly? Secretly? I was scared of you," I tell her. "Because you were right and I didn't know if I could tell you. And I didn't… I've been a coward because I couldn't ever tell you that you did the right thing. Not just for you, but also for her. And I'm really, really sorry it took me this long to say it Adora."

She wears astonishment so strangely. The tear had fallen, but none replace it. She's rigid, frozen where she stands with the beauty of Bright Moon as her backdrop. I must've said it wrong. I shouldn't have said it. It felt like the right thing. Slowly, she unwinds her arms from around herself, the taught tension easing from her as she leans back on her elbows against the rail.

She can barely meet my eyes as she softly says, "No one… No one's ever told me that before."

"Well gosh darnit, they *should've* !" I point at her emphatically and she jumps slightly in surprise. I wonder if now is a good time for a hug? Maybe not. She still looks fragile. I drop my pincer and join her back at the railing. "Are you okay? I said a lot."

"No, it's okay. I'm…" Adora pauses and takes a deep breath. Her expression relaxes into a more neutral one, a weary one. I recognize it, having seen it across the rebellion's camps during the worst of the invasion, but there was a calm to it. She opens her hand to reveal the golden trinket once more. "Thanks Scorpia.

That means a lot to me. That's actually kind of what I was up here thinking about."

"Do you wanna talk about it?" I ask quietly.

She seems to consider carefully, turning over the gold in her fingers as though turning over her thoughts. "Maybe…"

"Are you and Catra okay?"

"Yeah!" she says almost too quickly. "I mean, I think so. Maybe… I don't know. I'm not sure really what that means, I guess." She chuckles awkwardly, the mirth draining from her like a deflating balloon. "Everything is so different and we're all still adjusting. Catra is…"

Adora's hands freeze around the bauble and I get my first good look at it. A small golden wing. The symbol of Bright Moon. It matches the one she wears on her belt, but when I glance down, I see she's still wearing hers. I wonder why she has a second one then.

"All those things that happened back then," she says, her eyes transfixed on the wing. "Sometimes I wish I could go back to where this all started. Back before… before everything. There's so much I wish I could change. Do differently. But I know I can't and everything that happened led to this. And things are good now so that's okay. So can we… Is it possible to just move on? Is that an option?"

I blink, processing what Adora just said. "Ooh dang that's… uh… that's a tough one." I tap my pincer on my chin. "I get what you're saying though. It took a lot to get here, but I mean, I've never been happier. And who's to say anything would change for the better."

She doesn't seem to hear me. She lightly raps the tips of the metal wing against her knuckles, frowning down at them. "I think we can move on. I mean, I did. Or at least, I want to."

I blow out a long breath and lean back on my elbows. “Yeesh. It’s a lot, isn’t it?”

She smiles wanly. “That’s one way of putting it.”

“Gosh, Adora. I don’t know. I think about it sometimes. How can I just be here? How can any of this be okay? We fought and fought. All those things we were taught in the Horde—about our enemies and duties and purpose—none of that really matters anymore.” I glance sideways at her, still studying the medallion. “But it’s like, without the Horde, do I really have a purpose anymore and sometimes I wonder if I ever had one. I know we were lied to a lot, but some of it had to be true, right?”

“I…” Adora frowns and tilts her head. “I think so. Most of it was lies, but… I like to think that our friendships were real. That it was the one thing they couldn’t control about us.” She turns to me, a small twist of a hopeful smile.

“That was the hardest part, I think. Figuring all that out…” I let out a long sigh and slump against the railing. “I didn’t really know what to think or how to act. It was weird, wasn’t it?”

“Huh?” She meets my eyes, brow furrowing.

“When you came to Bright Moon. It was just… weird right?” I turn, resting back against the rail, and sweep my arm to indicate the castle rising against the ridgeline. The waterfalls glowed in the setting sunlight, casting rainbows across the zeniths of the towers. “No drills, no wake up calls, and people… smiled at you. I mean c’mon—you felt it, too.”

“Hah, yeah.” She shrugs noncommittally. “I guess.”

“And we’re just… we just have to be different now, you know? We had to learn how to be this way.” I nod at some of the passing guards, the citizens of Bright Moon so at ease in their home. “They didn’t. They kept being the people they always were. Wonderful and kind and loving people. So we had to just… you know… roll with it. Because what can we do? We can’t *not* .” I

pause and frown. “I guess we could, but that’d be super rude.” I shake the thought from my head and turn back to Adora. “No, we just kinda need to let things be good and okay. And everything else seems to sort itself out.”

She nods slowly, considering, turning the medallion over as though turning her thoughts over.

I set a pincer gently on her shoulder. “I had to learn how to trust that. You did too. And now, I think it’s Catra’s turn.”

“But what if…” The words die in her throat and she scowls down at her hand. She looks back up at me with a conflict of emotions similar to the face I saw before. Her certainty hangs on a knife edge. She’s not the Adora I recognize. In the twilight of Bright Moon, she doesn’t look like a soldier or a fighter. She doesn’t even look like the woman who can summon She-Ra. She looks like a person facing the most terrifying uncertainty. It always feels so easy to forget she’s a person with all the things she’s faced down and done for us. And a person needs a hand. “Scorpia.”

I’m a little taken aback by her directness, but I say, “Yeah?”

“Do you…” Another brief falter before she says, “Do you think she can do it?”

“Oh, of course!” I brush her concern away with a wave of my pincer. “She’s Catra. She’s gotten through more than any of us.”

“I guess…” Adora holds up the wing, studying them against the pastel sky. “Angella gave me my first pair of these when I got here. She thought it’d be a good way to show everyone what side I was on so they’d stop trying to kill me.”

“Okay, what’s *with* that?” I say exasperatedly. “I showed up and I had to run for my *life* before they stopped throwing things. Even *you* did it!”

Adora smirks. “To be fair, you showed up in the middle of a war meeting.”

"Well… I didn't want to interrupt."

"They don't like Horde soldiers just showing up, I guess. Bow did mention the pitchforks and torches to me at least—not that I listened to him." She nudges me with an elbow. "I'm just glad I didn't have to face Frosta down."

I chuckle at the memory. "She's only *slightly* less terrifying than Glimmer."

Adora's smile broadens, and I suspect she's about the laugh, but then it fades when she looks at the medallion again. "I'm just worried…" She pinches the wing between her thumb and forefinger, sunlight glinting off the refulgent metal. "We were different, you know? We walked away. We came here because we chose to. But Catra never did. That choice was taken from her. I know I can push her sometimes and I don't want to, but I can't always tell what she's thinking so I'm…" Another thought dies in birdsong around us. "I thought maybe giving her a set of the wings might help."

I grab her by the shoulders and shake her. "That's a great idea!"

My enthusiasm catches her off-guard, some of her hair dislodging from its ponytail as I jostle her. I collect myself and let her go. She only stands there, slightly stunned.

"I mean… I just think that she might…" I clear my throat, trying to organize my thoughts. "Perfuma has this thing about grounding, right? Roots or something. Those things that keep plants upright. I'm not as good with her metaphors." I make a strange digging motion with my pincers, trying to illustrate my point. Adora's expression only deepens in confusion so I stop. "But anyway, the idea is that you have to find something to grab onto and *maybe* if she has something like that it might help her if she gets a little lost or whatever." I beam and bump her on the shoulder with a pincer. "Plus it matches yours so it's even better!"

The confusion eases from her expression and she looks down at the medallion in her hand. The smile that graces her lips now is earnest and heartfelt. She looks back at me and I feel the warmth of her affection for Catra. It's more than I've ever seen her smile since the Heart. That genuine glowing grin as she rubs her thumb over the golden wings. Things are settling, and the tension and fear around us lessens.

"Thanks, Scorpia," Adora says. "That really helped."

"Any time!" I smile brightly at her. "Perfuma says I'm getting pretty good at this advice thing. I figure it's the least I can do after everything you've done for us."

Adora's smile turns a little rueful. "Glad to know you don't hate me anymore."

"Oh, c'mon. I never hated you!" I whap her bracingly on the back and she staggers forward a step. "Hate is such a strong word. Intense dislike maybe. You were pretty annoying in the Northern Reach though."

"So I've heard." She laughs wanly. She looks down at the wing in her hand and clutches them tightly in her fist. "I hope you're right about these."

"Oh, I'm definitely right." I place my pincers on my hips. "Our Wildcat's gonna love 'em."

Adora cocks her head at me in confusion. "Wildcat? What—" Her eyes drift to something behind me and she freezes mid-sentence, her face draining of color. She hastily locks her closed hand behind her back.

I turn to see Catra walking toward us, Melog at her heels. The normally adorable face looks as forlorn as Catra's. I don't understand their bond, but they're going through a lot together. Perfuma trails behind her, wearing that gentle, warm grin that brings the daylight like the sun cresting over the sea. She'd never know how beautiful those crinkles look in the corners of her eyes,

or the delicate aura of happiness that surrounded her like the flowers that grew everywhere around her. But I felt it. And I hope I can tell her about it someday.

"Hey, Adora," Catra says as she approaches us. Her voice is strained but she carries a wan smile. Straightening her catwalks must sure be exhausting.

"Catra." Adora's smile blossoms like one of Perfuma's flowers, the moment of slight panic already in the past. "You doing okay?"

Catra heaves a slow sigh. Her hand absentmindedly brushes along Melog's head where they sit next to her. "Yeah… Just… a lot."

Perfuma holds her hands clasped in front of her. "Unlocking chakras can be a taxing experience. I suggest you take it easy tonight and drink lots of water."

There's a tightness to Catra's eyes as she smiles at her. "Thanks, Perfuma."

"Of course! We'll pick it up again in a few days."

Adora holds out her arms, low and in front of her waist. A reserved gesture—an invitation that could be accepted or denied. Catra doesn't even hesitate, but intertwines her arms through Adora's and lets her pull them closer. She leans in and touches their foreheads gently together. Melog wraps themselves around their legs, tail curling so as to encompass them both. It's only moments before a creaky purr starts low in Catra's chest. Whatever discomfort Catra had before was already forgotten.

Perfuma sidles up closer to me; the delicate bouquet of her flowers is rose and tulips today. Aromas I never knew were possible back in my former life. But now they are, and I get to experience them every day. She tugs gently on my pincer pulling me a little further away. I follow a little reluctantly, but Catra and Adora are almost on a completely different plane of existence. I doubt they are aware of anything else around them.

“You have a good time with Adora?” Perfuma asks quietly, as we walk away.

“Oh, yeah.” I put my arm around her shoulders. “I was looking for you. I wanted to… to…” I tap the tip of my pincer on my chin. “You know, I don’t really know anymore.”

She goes up on her tiptoes to peck a kiss gently on my cheek. “If it’s important, it will find its way back to you.”

“How’s she doing?”

“There is a lot of spiritual disharmony in her. She’s been open to my guidance, but there are quite a few boundaries she still needs to cross.” She pauses, trouble encroaching on her tranquility. “I’m worried about her.”

“Well, she’s Catra, and she’s got Adora. If they can save Etheria, I think they can figure out some bad feelings.” I spare a glance over my shoulder, hearing the soft murmur of conversation from the two of them. Is Adora going to give it to her now?

“I hope so.” Perfuma’s arm tightens around mine. “They have a long way, but they’re walking the path of love together.”

I pull her behind a topiary. I can’t help it. Curiosity killed the Catra but an Adora brought her back. Perfuma tugs again on my pincer but I resist. I peer around the edge of the shrub, past the spatulate leaves. Catra is holding tight to Adora now, her face tucked into her red jacket. Adora embraces her, the medallion glinting in the setting sunlight where she held it behind Catra’s back.

“Scorpia, we shouldn’t—”

“Shh! I wanna see how it goes.”

Reluctantly, Adora lets Catra go. Catra’s tail flicks in slight agitation behind her as Adora holds up the golden wings of Bright Moon between them. That little broach can mean so much. The

wings that she carried in place of the brand of the Evil Horde. Her head is downturned, focused on the medallion and not Catra's face. Melog glances between the two of them, tilting their head in curiosity. I can't hear what Adora says, but I can see the sincerity and determination in her expression. The unbridled hope.

An unbearably long pause follows in its wake, dissonant with the pleasant birdsong of a Bright Moon evening and the distant thundering of the waterfalls. A cold wave of dread starts at the base of my neck but it's usurped by a rush of joy as Catra reaches up with both of her hands and gently takes the wings from Adora.

Another quiet something shared between the two of them. A slight nod from Catra, eliciting a dumbfounded, numb nod from Adora in response. The melodic chuckle of Catra carries over to us. She wraps her arms around Adora's neck and pulls her into an inevitable kiss.

I turn to Perfuma. "Okay, now we can go."

She smiles at me. "What'd you do?"

"Oh, nothing really." I lead Perfuma away from the gardens and the beauty of the balcony of Bright Moon. "We all like to help in our own ways."

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